INTIMIDATION (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Intimidation is a **Charisma** skill. It is used to influence someone through **overt threats**, **hostile actions**, or **physical violence**. With the **Influence** action, a **Charisma (Intimidation)** check can intimidate a **monster**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. With the **Influence** action, describe or act out how you threaten the monster: a **Charisma (Intimidation)** check.
2. The **default DC** is **15** or the monster's **Intelligence** score, whichever is higher.
3. Request in line with its desires: **no check**. Request it finds repugnant: **refusal**, no check.
4. If it hesitates, the check is affected by its **attitude**: Indifferent (nothing), Friendly (**Advantage**), or Hostile (**Disadvantage**).
5. **Failure**: wait **24 hours** (or the DM's duration) before threatening the same way.

Example: Brann (Charisma +1, Proficiency +2) threatens an indifferent bandit chief (Intelligence 10, DC 15). He rolls 12 + 1 + 2 = 15: success, the bandit lays down his weapons.

⚠ Using another ability:

- The ability of a check is **decided by the situation**: if a dwarf fighter uses brute force to intimidate, the DM may ask for **Strength (Intimidation)**.
- The **Proficiency Bonus** applies when the skill **fits** and you are proficient.
- See the **Use cases** page.

⚠ Point of attention

The **Influence** action sets the DC (15 or the monster's Intelligence), the attitude, and the 24-hour delay. Intimidation doesn't require the monster to understand you, unlike **Persuasion** and **Deception**.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The text doesn't say how long the fear lasts, nor whether failure makes the monster more hostile. Fix: the **DM announces before the roll** what "yielding" means (backing off, talking, surrendering).

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

Describe the unblinking stare, the lengthening shadow, the cracking knuckles, the silence settling in.

Step 1 – Decide whether a roll is needed:

If the request **fits the monster's desires**, no roll. If it finds it **repugnant**, it refuses with no roll. A roll happens only if the monster **hesitates**.

Step 2 – Take the Influence action:

You describe your threat. The check is **Charisma** (**Intimidation**) to intimidate a monster. No shared language is required.

Step 3 – Set the DC and attitude:

Monster's attitude	Effect on the check
Friendly	Advantage
Indifferent	No effect
Hostile	Disadvantage

Default DC: **15** or the monster's **Intelligence** score, whichever is higher.

Step 4 – Make the roll:

d20 + Charisma modifier + **Proficiency Bonus** if you are proficient in Intimidation. An ally can use the **Help** action to give you **Advantage**.

Example: Brann (Charisma +1, Proficiency +2) threatens an indifferent bandit chief (Intelligence 10, DC 15). He rolls 12 + 1 + 2 = 15: success, the bandit lays down his weapons.

Step 5 – Resolve:

- **Success**: the monster does what is asked.
- **Failure**: wait **24 hours** (or the DM's duration) before threatening the same way.
- A 20 or a 1 on the d20 **changes nothing** on an ability check.

Intimidation uses in the 2024 rules:

Situation	Check and DC
Influence action: intimidate a monster	Charisma (Intimidation), DC 15 or monster's Intelligence (higher)
Request fits the monster's desires	No check
Request the monster finds repugnant	No check: refusal
Hesitant monster: Friendly / Hostile attitude	Advantage / Disadvantage on the check
Persuasion and Deception	Require a monster that understands you; Intimidation does not

When one use case leads to another: Table rule

First check	Consequence	Next use case
Intimidation succeeds	The monster yields	Fight avoided, information gained, or surrender
Intimidation fails	24-hour wait	Another approach: Persuasion, Deception, Performance, Animal Handling
Strength (Athletics): break an object	You impress	Strength (Intimidation) to back the threat (Athletics sheet)
Study on the creature	You know its fears	Better-aimed threat: the DM may grant Advantage
Hostile attitude	Disadvantage on the check	Calm it first: Persuasion or Animal Handling

Chain example: Brann snaps a chair with one hand (Athletics) in front of an indifferent guard. He then threatens (Strength (Intimidation), DC 15), with Advantage granted by the DM: he rolls 9 and 13. He keeps the 13: 13 + 3 + 2 = 18, success. The guard backs off.

Ability + skill combinations: Table rule

*The DM decides the ability by the situation and applies proficiency if it fits. These combinations are **exceptions announced before the roll**.*

Combination	Use in play
Strength (Intimidation)	Break an object, bend bars, or lift a massive table to threaten.
Dexterity (Intimidation)	Show off speed or skill (juggling knives, planting a dagger near an ear).
Constitution (Intimidation)	Take a blow without flinching to show you are unshakable.
Intelligence (Intimidation)	Coldly lay out what you know about the target to chill them.
Wisdom (Intimidation)	Read the target's fear and aim at their weak spot.

Neighboring skills:

Skill	Use in play
Charisma (Performance)	Play out a theatrical rage to bend the target.
Charisma (Deception)	Bluff about your means or reputation to impress.
Charisma (Persuasion)	Convince a monster that understands you, without threatening it.

How to choose: Table rule

1. What does the task demand: **power, agility, endurance, mind, presence**? That gives the ability.
2. Which skill describes the **know-how**? Apply proficiency if it fits.
3. The DM **announces** the combination and the DC before the roll.

*Example: Mira (Constitution +2, Intimidation proficiency +2) takes a staff blow without flinching before bandits, DC 15. She rolls 11 + 2 + 2 = 15: success, the bandits hesitate. See also the **Athletics** sheet.*

Common table questions.

Intimidation or Persuasion?

Intimidation: threats, hostile actions, violence. **Persuasion**: convincing a monster that understands you.

Do I need to speak the monster's language?

No: only Persuasion and Deception require it to understand you. A threatening gesture is enough.

Can I intimidate a player character?

The Influence action targets a monster. For a player character, the player decides the reaction.

Table rule

Does fear cause the Frightened condition?

No, unless a spell or feature says so. Succeeding on Influence simply makes the monster do what is asked.

What happens on a failure?

Wait 24 hours (or the DM's duration) before the same approach. Table option: the monster's attitude may worsen. Table rule

Can I use Intimidation with Strength?

Yes: the ability is decided by the situation. See the **Use cases** page.

Table rule

Is a 20 an automatic success?

No: on an ability check, a **20** or a **1** has no special effect.

Which features help?

Expertise doubles the Proficiency Bonus. The Rogue can treat a 9 or lower as a 10. The **Help** action gives Advantage.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

20 and 1 on a check

On an ability check, a 20 or a 1 has no special effect: no Critical Hit, no automatic failure.

Check, attack and save

These are three distinct d20 rolls: a rule that affects one applies to the others only if it says so.

Fear and line of sight

The Frightened condition imposes Disadvantage only if you can see the source of fear: you can't have line of sight to what you can't see.

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